DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Do We Believe in God or Know Him?

Derech Hashem 1:1:1

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 1, Chapter 1, paragraph 1 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Tuesday 29 December 2020

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap and the start of Part 1

The Rabbi recalled the introduction: wisdom must be ordered like a beautiful orchard, not mixed up like a forest, and since no one can hold every detail, the main thing is to learn kelalim, principles, and how each one relates to the next. That is the purpose of Derech Hashem: to set out the principles of our emunah.

Part 1 is about the foundations of existence, and its main subject is Hakadosh Barukh Hu Himself. It has five chapters. Chapter 1 is about Hashem; Chapter 2 moves to the purpose of creation, because first we must know what Hashem is. Much of this chapter draws on the Rambam, so those who attended the earlier shiurim on the Thirteen Principles would see overlap, but the Ramhal frames things in his own way.

The first paragraph

"Every Jew must believe and know that there is a First Being (Masui Rishon), without beginning and eternal, who brought into being and sustains everything that exists, and this is Hashem."

The Rabbi noted that "every Jew" (kol ish miYisrael) does not exclude women: ish here means every Jewish person. He also pointed out that the term Masui Rishon is taken directly from the Rambam, who coined it.

Believe or know?

The Ramhal asked us to weigh every word, so why "believe and know"? Do I believe, or do I know?

First explanation. Emunah can carry the sense of believing something without fully knowing it. Yediah is stronger and more factual. As children, most of us are taught things by our parents and accept them: "That's what my father told me, that's what my grandfather told me." That is emunah, and it is not sufficient. These things have to become so clear that they are no longer something I believe but something I know. You would never say "I believe one and one equals two."

His example: a man's car has not moved for a week and his phone goes to a foreign ring tone. You believe he has gone away, but you do not know, since there could be other explanations. You know when you see him leave, or he tells you himself. "You can't just be a believer, you have to be a knower."

But I have not seen Hashem. The Rabbi acknowledged this is a fair question, often asked by teenagers and skeptics. One skeptic once told him that if God came and asked him to sacrifice his son he would do it too, but God never comes to him. The Rabbi's answer: you have never "seen" a mathematical truth either, especially an abstract one like algebra, yet you know it. Knowledge does not require sight. Something can be so clear that you know Hakadosh Barukh Hu exists.

Hokhmah, Binah and Daat

A participant asked why the Torah describes marital relations as "Adam knew Havah." The Rabbi said this ties in exactly, because daat means to connect to something. He then explained the three terms we pray for each day:

- **Hokhmah** is raw wisdom: a fact you are taught. Like a passive employee who does what he is told.
- **Binah** is understanding one thing from another: deriving a new fact from what you have learned. Like an active employee who uses his initiative.
- **Daat** is the highest: connecting to what you know, in your bones.

His example: you can learn the facts of Masekhet Eruvin (hokhmah), and derive new rulings from it (binah). But it is a different level when you walk down the street and see eruvin everywhere, recognising this wall and that post. "It's not just something intellectual in your head. You've connected to it. You're living with it." That is why the Torah calls intimacy daat: it is when you truly come to know a person. So belief may be where we start, but it has to end in knowledge.

A digression on science

A participant raised the old question of a tree falling in a forest with no one to hear it. The Rabbi answered that of course it makes a noise: we have seen trees fall countless times and they always make a noise. To doubt it would be to throw out all of science, since every experiment assumes the same result whether or not anyone is watching. Participants added stories of insights that seem to be "there all along" waiting to be discovered.

A second meaning of emunah

Throughout Tanakh, emunah means less "belief" and more loyalty, firmness and faithfulness. "You found his heart faithful (neeman) before You," said of Avraham, means You found him loyal and unflinching. In Yeshayahu, "I will fasten him as a peg in a firm (neeman) place." When we bless a hatan and kallah that they build a bayit neeman beYisrael, we mean a house committed to Torah, tradition and misvot.

So "believe and know" has two readings: 1. Believing is not enough; you must actually know. 2. You must know, and also be loyal and consistent to that knowledge, and live your life by it.

The Ramhal's sources

The Rabbi pointed out that the Ramhal quotes Hazal, the Gemara and the Midrashim constantly, but never later authorities such as Rashi or his own contemporaries, with one exception: the Rambam, whom he quotes in a number of places. "He went straight back to the source."

Rishon and Kadmon

If Hashem is Rishon, first, is He not obviously Kadmon, pre-existent? Why both words? The Rabbi offered two explanations.

First. Rishon means first as opposed to second, like the winner of a race. It says He came before everything else, but not necessarily that He was always there. Kadmon adds that He has always been. And Rishon is needed alongside Kadmon, because one could imagine two things that were always there; Rishon says He is before anything else.

Second. The Rambam holds that it cannot be proven with certainty that the world was created from nothing. The Ramban held that one who believes the world was created from something is a kofer. Ibn Ezra, as the Rabbi presented him, held that there was pre-existent matter (hiyuli) from which Hashem created the world. The Rambam leans towards creation from nothing but does not reject those who hold otherwise. The Ramhal may be negating that view: Hashem is Rishon and Kadmon, before anything at all.

He added a correction: we should not say "from the beginning of time," because time itself is a creation, a point the book would return to.

Summary

- Every Jew must both believe and know that there is a First Being, eternal and without beginning, who creates and sustains everything: this is Hashem.
- Emunah inherited from parents is a start, but it must become clear knowledge, as certain as a mathematical truth.
- Hokhmah is raw fact, binah is deriving from it, and daat is living connection; our knowledge of Hashem should reach daat.
- Emunah also means loyalty and consistency: knowing Hashem and living by it.
- Rishon and Kadmon together teach that nothing existed alongside or before Hashem.

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